Although the results of the economic reforms looked positive in the aggregate, Cuba's people did not benefit equally. A survey in Havana in 2000 showed 77 percent of the population had "insufficient income to cover their daily expenses;"[35] 42 percent of Cubans surveyed in 2007, and 43 percent in 2008, believed that low salaries and the high cost of living were the biggest problems facing their country.[36]

Older generations of Cubans may remember Cuba prior to the Revolution, and the headiness of social change and possibility of the 1960s, or at least the relative material stability of the 1970s and 80s. This background lent the changes of the 1990s and early 2000s a poignancy, or even anguish. For those who came of age in the Special Period of the 1990s, those early decades seem a distant chimera. Both those who lived the experiences, and those who learned about them in school, though, had to face contemporary realities that did not live up to revolutionary dreams. The Revolution was supposed to bring equality – but what was visible in the 1990s and beyond was a growing inequality. The Revolution was supposed to bring an end to national economic dependence and the neocolonial relations that entailed, but the 1990s brought a renewed influx of foreign tourists and foreign investment, now heralded as Cuba's salvation. The Revolution was supposed to create opportunities for Cuba's people by overcoming underdevelopment, but in the 1990s jobs and opportunities seemed to exist only abroad. The 1990s generation was also heavily exposed to a materialism and cynicism in global youth culture that hadn't touched previous generations – both because of changes in the nature of global youth culture, and because new technologies were creating quantum leaps in the global connectedness of youth.

Cuban blogger Yoani Sánchez described a "Generation Y" in her country, referring not only to the U.S. idea of a "Generation X" but also to the popularity of names, like hers, beginning with the letter Y: "Yanisleidi, Yoandri, Yusimí, Yuniesky." (In Cuba, as well as other parts of Latin America and especially the Caribbean, there has been a marked tendency to invent new names as the influence of the Catholic Church and the practice of giving children names from the Bible waned at the end of the twentieth century.) This generation, she writes, was "born in